



Unfazed by challenges: The consistency of D. Gukesh and Vidit Gujrathi in the Tata Steel Masters in Wijk aan Zee, the Netherlands, was a fine advertisement for Indian chess.

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Aronian. He beat the field in 2010, 2013, 2015, 2016, 2018, 2019, and 2022.

So, coming back to the competition in 2024, four-man knockout blitz tie-break games were needed to decide the champion. The players were given a standard starting time of three minutes plus a two-second increment per move. In the sudden death, the player with white pieces got 2.5 minutes.

Gukesh battled back from a 0-1 deficit against Anish by winning the second game and taking out the defending champion in sudden death for a place in the final.

In the other semifinal, Wei Yi was lucky to escape with a draw in the first game against Abdusattorov and then came through sudden death.

In the final, Wei's cool composure and Gukesh's subpar time

management combined to make him the first Chinese champion since the inception of the event in 1938. Gukesh had his chances in the first game, which ended in a draw, but in the second, he stayed low on time and finally blundered a rook.

Wei, who lost the second round to Gukesh, was playing only his second tournament outside China after the pandemic. He bounced back into title contention by winning the last three games, including the final round against Vidit.

Seeded eighth in a strong field of 14 players, Wei surprised himself by winning the strongest tournament of his career. Tenth seed Gukesh, the lowest ranked among the three Indians, won six games, starting with his second-round conquest of Wei.

Though defeats to World Champion Ding Liren and Anish in succession set him back, he responded brilliantly by winning the following three rounds against Russian Ian Nepomniachtchi and the Dutch duo Jorden van Foreest and Max Warmerdam.

Thereafter, among others, Gukesh drew with Vidit and allowed

Praggnanandhaa to slip away with a draw.

Praggnanandhaa's alertness ended the contest when he claimed a third-time repetition of the position in the presence of an arbiter.

Gukesh did not allow this disappointment to dampen his spirits, and he won an exciting final round against flashy Iranian Parham Maghsoodloo to tie for the title. A gain of 18 rating points underlined his superlative showing in such a strong field.

A lot of credit is due to Vidit for the crowded first place at the end of 13 rounds. Triumphant over the fancied Alireza Firouzja in the seventh round, Vidit opened the title race with a penultimate-round win over leader Abdusattorov before losing to Wei.

Praggnanandhaa was the epitome of consistency. He defeated the two Chinese World Champions, Ding Liren and Ju Wenjun, drew against the rest, and marginally raised his rating by four points.

Overall, it was a terrific performance from the three Indians preparing for their biggest test when